

Leo's Auto: quick interview

Opening:

"We're doing a small Towson University database class project. Could you explain how you track a repair from arrival to payment? We only need general information, not customer records. May I take notes?"

Date / time

09/29/2026 / 4:45 PM

Place or call/video

In-person at the shop

Student(s) present

Mae Beeman

Person interviewed

Brooke Maenner

Their role

Daughter / Front Desk Manager

1. Quick business profile

Proposed site: Leo's Auto Inc., 14 Willow Ave, Towson, MD 21286. Confirm or correct the name/address below. Approximate answers are fine; sales can be "not disclosed."

History, location(s), staff/size, service area, main services, optional sales

Confirmed: Leo's Auto Inc., 14 Willow Ave, Towson, MD 21286.
Family-owned and operated; founded by Leo. One location, about 5-6 staff.
Family runs the front desk; mechanics handle repairs. Serves Towson and the surrounding area. General auto repair, maintenance, A/C, brakes and tire repair.
No car sales; service only.

2. What tools do you use now? Anything hard to track?

Software / paper / other; one issue or improvement (or "works fine")

Digital shop management software for estimates, plus paper Repair Orders (ROs) for mechanics. Difficulties: finding older paper records for warranty checks and tracking physical part returns to NAPA when the wrong item is delivered.

3. Walk me through a normal repair, from arrival to pickup.

Who does each step? What is written down or entered? Include estimate/approval and payment.

Actual steps, in order

1. Brooke checks in the customer, records details/complaint and prints an RO.
2. Mechanic takes car/RO to bay, diagnoses and writes parts/labor on the RO.
3. Brooke prices parts/labor and calls the customer for estimate approval.
4. After approval, Brooke orders parts; the mechanic completes the repair.
5. Brooke finalizes the invoice in the system.
6. Customer pays in full by cash/card at pickup and receives the keys.

What information do we need?

4. What details do you record?

Customer details (e.g., name, phone, business/fleet account)

Name, phone number and sometimes email. Mainly personal/family vehicles; few fleet accounts.

Vehicle details (e.g., VIN, plate, make/model/year, mileage)

VIN, license plate, make, model, year and exact mileage at arrival.

Repair/job details (e.g., complaint, diagnosis, approval, status, mechanic)

Initial complaint, mechanic diagnosis/notes, customer approval status and assigned mechanic.

5. How do these records connect?

Can one customer have several vehicles? Can a vehicle have several owners/contacts? Can several mechanics work on one job? What happens when a vehicle changes owners?

Answers / exceptions (yes, no, unsure + a short explanation)

One customer may have several vehicles under a family profile. One vehicle is linked to one owner; on sale, create the new customer profile and relink the vehicle, preserving its history. Usually one mechanic per job; rarely several.

6. How do you record labor and parts?

Labor: hours, flat price, or both? Parts: stocked or bought per job? When does stock go down, and what happens to unused/returned parts?

Labor pricing and parts/stock rules

Labor: flat-rate guide hours x hourly rate; diagnostics use flat hours/hourly pricing. Parts usually bought per job from local suppliers. Oil, filters and bulbs stocked; counts reduced manually when used. Unused parts returned for credit.

7. How do approval, bills and payments work?

How is approval recorded? What makes up the total (labor, parts, tax/fees)? Any partial payments, deposits or refunds? Can an old invoice change?

Short answers; note anything we should ask about later

Approval: verbal by phone; name/time written on RO. Total: parts, labor, shop supplies and state tax. No deposits or partial payments; cash/card in full at pickup. Closed, paid invoices cannot change; issue a separate credit/refund.

Finish with priorities and proof

8. What should a small class prototype do first?

Which 2-3 tasks, searches or reports are useful? For example, finding repair history, viewing open jobs or checking unpaid bills. Ask them to choose.

Top tasks / reports

1. Search customer repair history by phone number.
2. Open Jobs dashboard showing status, including waiting for parts and ready for pickup.

9. What happens when something goes wrong?

Ask about a cancellation, declined work, wrong entry or missing part. One common example is enough.

Example and what the shop does

Wrong part delivered: mechanic reports it; Brooke requests a vendor exchange and notes the delay on the RO. If needed, move the car off the lift and call the customer with the revised pickup time.

10. Anything to correct, or a question we should follow up on?

No corrections or additional follow-up questions stated.
Brooke agreed to note-taking for the Towson University class project.

Business name / blank form / photo use permitted? Any restrictions?

Business name use allowed. Exterior/front desk photos discouraged; no plates or PII.

Interview confirmation

This signature confirms that the interview above took place. It does not approve our report, commit the business to using our software, or endorse the project.

Interviewee signature (sign by hand):



Signed electronically

Date signed: 09/29/2026